Trade Center in New York City and other targets. But this was the first time the public was made aware of the program continuing under the Obama administration. Even though the content of calls was not part of the data collected, the program allowed the NSA to know who was calling whom, where the callers were located, and at what times the calls were made.

The government deemed the program legal based on the Patriot Act, which was passed in 2001 to strengthen domestic security and broaden the powers of law enforcement to fight terrorism. Specifically, 50 US Code Section 1861 of the Patriot Act allows the Federal Bureau of Investigation (FBI) to collect "any tangible things (including books, records, papers, documents, and other items) for an investigation to obtain foreign intelligence information."[4]

METADATA

Many of the NSA's programs collect metadata, which are the details of a communication, not the content itself. An example of phone call metadata would be the phone number of the caller and receiver, how long the call lasted, and when the call was made. It would not include a recording of the call. E-mail metadata would include the sender and receiver's e-mail addresses and when it was sent, but it would not include the subject or text of the e-mail.

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